

Scotland at War - Kids

UK Family Tour

Scotland Goes to War

Here's something strange to think about while you're in Edinburgh. In both world wars, the big battles happened far away from Scotland, across the sea in France and Germany. No army ever invaded here. So why did the wars keep coming to Scotland anyway?

Look at a map and you'll see the answer. Scotland points straight at Germany across the North Sea, and its coast is full of huge, sheltered bays where a whole navy can hide. So that's exactly what Britain's navy did. Hundreds of warships anchored in Scottish waters, including the wide river mouth right next to Edinburgh, the Firth of Forth, the same water you'll sail across in a boat this week. And because the ships were here, the fighting came here too. The very first German air raid on Britain in the Second World War happened right over that water, with Spitfires chasing bombers past the Forth Bridge while people watched from the streets of Edinburgh. A few years before that, at the end of the First World War, the entire German navy, seventy warships, sailed into this same firth and surrendered. Up in the mountains, commandos and secret agents trained for the most dangerous missions of the war. And a Scottish scientist invented a machine that could spot enemy planes in the dark, from a hundred miles away.

Once you know all this, you'll start seeing clues everywhere. There's a memorial full of names inside Edinburgh Castle. There are old gun platforms and a secret tunnel on the island you'll visit on day ten. From the top of Arthur's Seat you'll see the whole battlefield of sea and sky spread out below you. So keep your eyes open. This week, you're walking through a giant detective story, and the mystery is how a small, faraway country ended up in the middle of two world wars.

Spitfires Over the Forth

Imagine you're standing in Princes Street on an ordinary Monday afternoon, and you look up, and there's a real air battle happening in the sky above the Forth Bridge. That actually happened, on the sixteenth of October, nineteen thirty-nine, just six weeks after the Second World War began. Twelve German bombers came roaring across the North Sea to attack navy warships anchored in the Firth of Forth, the same water your boat will cross on day ten. And the amazing part? The air raid sirens never went off. The warning system failed completely. So nobody hid in shelters. People just stood in the streets and on the beaches, watching planes chase each other around the sky, and lots of them thought it was a practice drill. Golfers kept right on playing golf.

But it was real. And racing up to meet the bombers came Spitfires flown by two squadrons of part-time pilots, six-oh-two from Glasgow and six-oh-three from Edinburgh. These weren't full-time soldiers. They were lawyers and farmers and businessmen who trained as fighter pilots on weekends, and now enemy bombers were attacking their own home town. The Spitfires chased the bombers right over the Forth Bridge and shot two of them down into the sea. Those were the very first German planes shot down over Britain in the whole Second World War, and it happened here, not over London. The German commander was fished out of the water near a fishing village and taken prisoner. Sadly it wasn't all exciting, because bombs hit the ships and sixteen sailors died. One captain was badly hurt but refused to leave his post

until he had steered his ship safely home. That took real courage. And just twelve days later, the same Scottish squadrons brought down another German plane on a hillside at Humble, not far from Edinburgh, the first enemy plane to crash on British soil in the whole war. The message to the bombers was clear: Scotland's skies were guarded.

One more secret. This wasn't even the first time Edinburgh was attacked from the air. Way back in nineteen sixteen, during the First World War, a giant German airship called a Zeppelin, longer than a football pitch, floated over the city at night and dropped bombs. One landed in the Grassmarket, right below the castle. When you walk through the Grassmarket, look down. There's a special stone in the pavement outside the White Hart Inn marking the exact spot. See if you can find it.

The Day a Whole Navy Gave Up

Picture the biggest parade you've ever seen, then make it out of warships. On the twenty-first of November, nineteen eighteen, just after the First World War ended, the entire German navy sailed into the Firth of Forth to surrender. Seventy German warships came across the sea in a long grey line, and waiting for them were nearly two hundred Allied ships, arranged in two giant columns with a gap down the middle, like a guard of honour that was also a trap. The German fleet had to sail right up the middle while thousands of sailors watched from the decks on either side, guns ready, just in case. Nothing happened. At sunset the British admiral sent his famous order: the German flag comes down today, and does not go up again. The war at sea was over, and it ended right here, on the water you'll sail across.

But the story has a wild twist. The captured ships were taken north to a huge bay in the Orkney islands called Scapa Flow, where they sat for seven months while the winners argued about who would keep them. The German admiral listened to the arguing and made a secret plan. One June morning in nineteen nineteen, he gave a signal, and every German crew pulled the plugs on their own ships. All at once, on purpose, they sank their entire navy. Fifty-two giant warships rolled over and disappeared, and, unbelievably, a boatload of Orkney schoolchildren on a day trip sailed right into the middle of it and watched battleships turning upside down around them. Best or worst school trip ever? Some of those wrecks are still down there, and divers visit them today.

Scapa Flow has one more story, a sad one that turns hopeful. In the Second World War a German submarine sneaked in and sank a battleship called Royal Oak, and more than eight hundred sailors died, many of them boys still in their teens. To make sure no submarine ever sneaked in again, Britain built massive stone barriers across the channels, and the builders were Italian prisoners of war. Those prisoners were given two curved metal huts, and out of scrap metal and paint and pure skill they turned them into a beautiful little chapel, with a painted ceiling like an Italian church. It's still there, and people from all over the world visit it. Even in the middle of a war, somebody chose to build something beautiful.

Edinburgh Kids at War

What was it actually like to be a kid in Edinburgh during the Second World War? Strange, scary, and sometimes weirdly boring. At night the whole city went completely dark. It was called the blackout, and it meant every window covered, every streetlight off, so German bombers couldn't find the city from the air. Kids carried gas masks to school in little cardboard boxes, and practised putting them on until the rubber smell made them dizzy. Many families had an air raid shelter buried in the back garden, a curved metal hut covered with soil, where you'd huddle with a torch and a blanket when the sirens howled. Thousands of Edinburgh children were evacuated, which means they were sent away from the city to farms and villages where bombs were less likely to fall. They travelled with a label tied to their coat, like a parcel, not knowing when they'd see home again. Some hated it. Some loved farm life so much they didn't want to come back.

And the food. Nearly everything was rationed, which means each person was only allowed a small fixed amount: a little butter, a little meat, one egg a week sometimes. And one fact shocks every kid: sweets were rationed too, and sweet rationing didn't end until nineteen fifty-three, eight years after the war was over. Imagine being allowed only a tiny bag of sweets a month for your whole childhood. When sweets finally came off the ration, kids across Britain emptied the shops in celebration. Clothes were rationed too, so families patched and mended everything. The government even had a slogan for it, make do and mend, and kids grew up wearing jumpers unravelled from old ones and knitted again in a new size.

The war left marks all over Edinburgh, and you can hunt for them. Inside the castle there's a grand memorial holding books with the names of the Scottish soldiers who died, well over one hundred thousand names, so many that historians still argue about the exact count. On the Royal Mile, near the City Chambers, look for a big flat stone called the Stone of Remembrance. At Haymarket there's even a clock tower remembering a whole football team, Heart of Midlothian, whose players joined the army together. And almost every church and school has a plaque of names if you look. Each name was a real person from this city. Finding their names and reading a few out loud is a small way of saying: we remember you.

Secret Agents in the Mountains

Deep in the Scottish Highlands, far from any city, the war's most secret schools were hidden among the mountains. At a castle called Achnacarry, near Ben Nevis, the army trained commandos, soldiers picked for the most dangerous missions of all. The training was ferocious. Recruits ran for miles through the hills carrying heavy packs, crossed freezing rivers on ropes, climbed cliffs in the rain, and practised beach landings while real bullets were fired over their heads so they'd know the sound. More than twenty-five thousand men from many countries earned their green berets there. Today, on a hill at Spean Bridge, a big bronze statue of three commandos looks out over the mountains where they trained, standing exactly where the recruits used to march past on their way in.

Even more secret were the spy schools. In lonely hunting lodges on the west coast, secret agents learned how to blow up bridges, sneak past guards, and survive behind enemy lines. And near Aviemore, in the Cairngorm mountains, there was a hidden camp for Norwegian soldiers whose country had been captured by the Nazis. They trained in Scotland because the snowy mountains felt like Norway. Their greatest mission sounds like a movie, and it basically became one. In February nineteen forty-three, a small team of them parachuted onto a frozen plateau in Norway, skied through the winter night, climbed down an icy gorge everyone said was impossible, broke into a guarded factory, and blew up the machines the Nazis needed for building a terrifying new weapon. Then they skied away into the darkness. Nobody on the team was caught. It's often called the most perfect secret mission of the whole war, and the men who did it learned their skills in the Scottish mountains.

Now for the weirdest war story of all. One night in May nineteen forty-one, one of the most powerful Nazis in Germany, Rudolf Hess, secretly flew a plane to Scotland all by himself, without telling Hitler, because he had a crazy idea he could arrange peace. His plane ran out of fuel and he parachuted into a farm field near Glasgow, breaking his ankle. And who captured one of the most powerful men in Nazi Germany? A farm worker named David McLean, who found him lying in the field. The story goes that McLean grabbed a pitchfork to guard him, then took him back to the cottage, where the family sat this mysterious German by the fire and gave him a cup of tea. That's possibly the most Scottish capture in the history of war.

Shipyards, Radar, and Clues on the Beach

Scotland didn't only fight the world wars. It built them. On the river Clyde, near Glasgow, stood some of the most famous shipyards on Earth, where thousands of workers hammered together warships and giant liners. Saying a ship was Clydebuilt was like saying it was the best. In the Second World War

the Nazis knew exactly how important those shipyards were, so one terrible night in March nineteen forty-one, hundreds of bombers attacked the shipbuilding town of Clydebank. Most of the town's houses were wrecked in two nights, and more than five hundred people died. It was the worst bombing Scotland ever suffered. But there was one thing the bombers couldn't destroy: the people. Families who had lost their homes came back, the shipyard workers walked in from the villages where they were sheltering, and the yards kept building ships until the war was won. Lots of the workers were women, by the way. In the First World War, thirty thousand people, nearly half of them women, worked in a gigantic factory at Gretna stirring a dangerous explosive mixture with their bare hands. A famous writer, Arthur Conan Doyle, the man who invented Sherlock Holmes, visited and called the stuff devil's porridge.

Now meet the Scot who won a battle with an invention. Robert Watson-Watt, a radio scientist from a little town called Brechin, worked out in nineteen thirty-five that you could find an aeroplane in the sky by bouncing radio waves off it and catching the echo. That invention is called radar, and it could see through clouds and darkness, a hundred miles out to sea. When German bombers attacked Britain in nineteen forty, radar warned the Spitfire pilots exactly where to go, every single time. The Germans couldn't understand how the British always knew they were coming. The funny ending came years later, when Watson-Watt was stopped by police for driving too fast. What caught him? A radar speed gun. The story goes he told the officer, if I'd known what you'd do with it, I'd never have invented it.

The wars left clues all over Scotland, and you can still find them. Old airfields, lookout posts on cliffs, and little concrete forts called pillboxes hiding in the dunes. So here's a challenge for day thirteen, when your train heads south along the coast. Watch the beaches out the window. If you spot rows of big grey concrete cubes half-buried in the sand, those were put there in nineteen forty to stop German tanks coming ashore. Nobody ever moved them. The war ended more than eighty years ago, and its concrete is still sitting there on the beach, waiting for sharp-eyed detectives like you.